Wonderfully refreshing, this perfect hot summer's day lunch is fantastically quick to make and is superbly healthy. Serve it up with garlic-rubbed toast.

gazpacho

SERVES 6–8 **PREP** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

1 red bell pepper, seeded and chopped
10 scallions, trimmed and chopped, or 1 red onion, finely chopped
5 garlic cloves, chopped
1 cucumber, finely chopped
2¼lb (1kg) ripe tomatoes, finely chopped
1 tbsp fresh thyme, marjoram, parsley, mint, or basil, chopped
3–4 pieces stale bread
1 fresh chile, seeded and finely chopped, or ½ tsp cayenne pepper (optional)
2 tbsp red wine vinegar
3 tbsp olive oil, plus extra to serve
½ cup cold water
salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 Place a serving bowl in the refrigerator. Put the pepper, scallions or onion, garlic, cucumber, and tomatoes in a mixing bowl, then add the herbs.

2 Process the bread in a blender to make breadcrumbs, then add to the mixing bowl along with the chile, if using, the vinegar, and oil. Gradually add the water. ½ cup will give a good thick consistency but you can use more if you prefer.

3 Transfer to the blender and process briefly—you can blend until smooth, or so it still contains the odd chunk of cucumber. Season generously with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Transfer to the chilled serving bowl, add a few ice cubes, and drizzle with olive oil before serving.